Growing Claws

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/74010621.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
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English

Series:
Part 6 of Defiance - Raised in Halfmoon AU

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Of Wing & Claw - Apocrypha

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Growing Claws

by tp9829, Zelenal

Summary

After a few years in Halfmoon, Adora is determined to resume her training, if only someone would take a seven year old seriously.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Adora’s Room

The Cathedral

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Year After the Coup Attempt

Even after two years in the wondrous city, Adora was still often confused by details. Like why no one trained the way they were supposed to, why no one took notes like Shadow Weaver had taught her to do—Kesi had gone out on her birthday and got her several pads of paper and a pack of pencils which she used to keep track of everything, which was the best thing she had. They had gotten less use as things had gotten more familiar with her new home, but she still had one on her at all times.

Birthdays were another thing, Catra had had one so far—it was a big party (another new word) with lots of food and dancing and music which was all nice. Now, she apparently had two down here that were all much smaller than Catra’s—she *was* the Princess, after all—but Kesi had brought her cake and the notepads, and some of the cave culture people had made her jewellery which she kept in a box (a jewelry box, fittingly enough) in her small room. They didn’t know exactly when she was born, so they just said the day she became a Temple Daughter was her birthday. But she still didn’t really know why people celebrated it. When she had asked Kesi, the older girl had gotten one of her sad looks that all the adults got when she talked about something that made sense to her.

She had a room all to herself (like a Force Captain would) and it took a few weeks to get used to sleeping alone—on her first night here, she couldn’t manage it; it was too dark. She crept out and slept under a pew upstairs in the church where a fire was always

lit. Kesi found her in the morning sleeping and, when she tried to hide that she was scared, Kesi saw right through her. She came down later that day with a big box, and told her to decorate her room, to make it her own. Adora didn't know what that meant, but Kesi told her to pick what she liked out of the box and it would be hers.

"So, what do you want your room to be?" Kesi had asked her. A question that confused Adora; it was the cathedral's room, she thought. But, instead, Kesi had pulled out some paint, and a bunch of pictures all in small wooden frames.

"I can just choose?" She was staring into the box with wide eyes. She pulled out several pictures, mainly of animals she didn't recognise. One of a dragon, like she had seen in the picture book. Kesi had given her a look over the depiction of the great winged beast that inspired terror, but shrugged when Adora clutched it tight. That went over the top of her bed, which itself was the same size as her bed in the Horde but with a nicer, squisher mattress. Kesi had also hung around it some strange glass bulbs—each no bigger than a thumb—and, when she got down from the stool she had been standing on, she tapped something and they lit up in a soft, orange light.

"So it won't get too dark in here when you sleep." Kesi said it with a casual grace, like she did with everything. The girl was *so* cool. Adora launched at her and hugged her then; she had soothed Adora's fears without even thinking about it. Holding her tight with one arm, the older girl just patted her head and ran her hands through Adora's hair. She had seen Adora's problem and had fixed it while making it fun.

Eventually, everything was decorated. Her bed had new sheets—a bright red colour, like a Cadet Captain's coat—the dragon picture was hung up above her bed, and her desk had new paper and drawing supplies (a colouring book, Kesi had called it; as if she would deface such lovely pictures on purpose). The desk also had her list of daily chores; Kelara would come in and leave it every night for the next day. At first, Lyra had complained, but Adora

had liked having structure to her day, even if it was just for the morning. In the afternoon, she would go and see Catra, or go with Kesi or, as she planned to do today, go find King Tiger.

She had a footlocker which she filled with everything she had taken from the Horde: the clothes that she had been wearing, her knife, and the small lantern that King Tiger had given to her when they went down into the dark and had to deal with the scary people like Shadow Weaver. That had not been a nice journey; it was dark, aside from the lantern, and the people they met were mean. She was glad that Kyle had taught her how to turn on a skiff without a key or otherwise they might have all been captured by the mean people.

Her actual locker—people called it a closet here—was filled with new clothes, all of which she and Kesi had brought together. Everyone knew her; she was the cave culture kid from the surface, the only non-Magicat, and a member of the faith. She was an oddity; she wished she wasn't but at least being an oddity here didn't mean constant tests and being hurt by Shadow Weaver. Here, it just meant people had to stitch over the tail hole for their clothes for her and the cave culture people embraced her in kind, just like how the temple had given her a place to stay and something to believe in. So, her locker had been filled, her old Horde uniform had been stashed away and replaced with robes of the Cathedral, and her new clothes all sat next to those. She had more freedom than ever before.

The room was so big, it even had a separate room with a toilet and a shower and a sink. The people of Halfmoon lived in real luxury. Not having to shower as a group seemed so ridiculous but she was left alone with it.

Now she had been living in the room for two years, two years to get used to the wonder of it. She had even been in Catra's bedroom more than a few times. That one was *too* big—she was scared she might get lost in her locker—but Catra had seemed comfortable in it. She had pulled her into her nest—a space under the bed where nobody could find her, she had said. Of course,

that was spoiled when King Tiger came in and climbed under as well, muttering something about "Avoiding the Captain."

So, now she sat on the end of her bed, her hair still damp from the shower. She had done her morning chores, ticking off everything from the list. She had changed from her robe to something plain, *far* plainer than she would normally wear for an afternoon with Kesi: a simple shirt of blue cloth and long, dark, silk pants. She had also put on her leather boots (that was the most difficult thing and Kesi's mom had been nice about that; she had gone out of her way to learn how to make shoes for Adora and she had half a dozen pairs made by the woman). With her clothes changed, she would wait for Kelara to come; she had asked to speak to her before she went off with Kesi. She sat with the Horde knife: a simple length of metal stamped with the Horde emblem on one side and a squad number on the other. She twisted it over in her grip, running her finger over the embossed number—her squad number. She hoped they were doing well. Lonnie would keep them safe, and Kyle couldn't be blamed for, well, anything, really, except technical failures, and Rogelio was so small that she doubted he would be able to hurt anyone. She did feel at least a little bad for leaving them behind; they would love it here. Maybe they would be safe and Shadow Weaver would make sure they stayed behind in the Fright Zone.

She had no idea how long she spent sitting there turning that knife over in her hands when there was a sharp *knock* snapping her out of her daze (her hair was still wet so it couldn't have been that long). Taking the three steps to the door, she opened it, and curtseyed to Head Priestess Kelara.

"Thank you for coming to speak to me," She started formally. "There is something I need to discuss." She had rehearsed this speech in her head; she would sound polite, sophisticated, and she wouldn't whine.

"Of course, Temple Daughter. May I come in?" The older woman gestured into the room. Adora nodded, stepping back from the door. She took a seat on the bed, crossing her legs, while Kelara

took the small wooden chair at the desk. It was designed for someone half her height but it was better than standing. After she had sat, the priestess turned her gaze to Adora. "So, what can I help you with, Temple Daughter?"

She took a deep breath and said, "I want to go back to training," with all the conviction her seven-year-old body could muster. "I want to be a temple guard like Lynn or Tobin." Those two were always nice to her, and said one day she would grow up big and strong, but she would only grow up big and strong, she reasoned, if she could train to make herself strong.

The woman let out a long-suffering sigh that only a parent could understand. "Adora, we've talked about this." Adora began to pout but, before she could interject, Kelara continued, "You can resume your Horde training once you turn sixteen. Not before; it's for your own good."

Stupid magic number theory, Adora thought. *I bet I'm already better than most sixteen year olds that are training.* She had kept up her routine in—well, mostly secret; Kesi knew, Catra knew, she was certain that King Tiger and the Queen knew, and Dr. Lenio but nobody else. "But why? I am ready; I want to train. I want to be ready. Did I do something wrong?" The last point came out small.

Kelara reached out a hand and placed it on Adora's knee. "You did nothing wrong, child, but we do not want our kits off fighting wars, not like the Horde. When you come of age, you can choose to join the temple guard, as is your right as a temple daughter, but only once you have come of age. Until then, be a child, play with your friends. I know the Princess would miss you dearly if all the rest of your days were taken up with training." She would miss Catra if she had to train alone. "Your training on the temple grounds with the staff you keep under your bed is more than adequate until you are of age." She smirked down at Adora.

Adora looked sheepish at getting caught, cocking her head at the woman. "How'd you know about that?" she asked as if she hadn't

been seen sneaking off with a quarterstaff and following the palace and temple guards around like a lost kitten.

“I know many secrets, Adora,” she said with a grin. The girl looked at her wide-eyed. “That training will have to suffice. I cannot, in good conscience, send you to train amongst adults.”

The girl pouted. It was difficult to read her expression without expressive ears or a tail, but Kelara had spent two years studying how the girl acted to try and learn something about how she thought, skill lost in the burning of Halfmoon’s great forests now coming in useful.

“Have you thought about what the Queen and I asked?” the priestess continued. The girl suddenly stiffened. Her expression hardened.

“I do not want to, Temple Elder,” the girl said, her voice quavering. “I do not think I will ever want to.”

The priestess patted her knee. “That’s alright, Adora. The magic is yours; I cannot force you to study it, but it is my duty to ask. You hold so much light within you, it would be a shame not to at least know why.” The girl looked ashamed, and Kelara knew she had made a mistake at that moment. She went to say something.

Another knock on the door interrupted that train of thought. Adora looked up with a small “Come in.” The door opened and Kesi entered the room, dressed in her cave culture clothing.

“Adora, we’re going to be late to see—” she entered the room carrying a large bag of something, but stopped upon seeing the priestess. “Oh, Grandmother, I wasn’t expecting you.”

“That’s alright, I shan’t keep you or Adora any longer.” She turned to face the young girl. “Adora, what you ask is not something I can grant without the Queen's consent even if I wanted too, which I do not. But, please, I ask you to reconsider with your magic. It will be a far less dangerous path for you than what you would choose currently. However, if you turn ten and you are still

dedicated to this path then I will speak with Tobin about starting your training. That's only three years away." With that, the old woman left Adora sitting alone on the bed.

Kesi walked over and sat next to Adora who had picked up the knife and was staring down at it. Kesi leaned over to the younger girl, wrapping her tail around Adora's waist. Adora's free hand snaked down to pat the tip of the tail. "Sorry about her," she said to Adora. "What were you talking about?" She looked at the knife Adora was holding. It was hers, one of the few pieces of her old home that she had managed to salvage, and a reminder of who she wanted to be: a soldier. Kesi couldn't understand the love of that life but, for the young girl, it was always her dream to one day fight. "Training again?"

Adora looked up and nodded. "They won't let me until I turn sixteen, which is soooo far away. What happens if something happens between now and then: what if the Horde attacks? Or the goblins? Or theirs another coup? Kesi, I need to be ready!" The girl was practically hyperventilating by the end.

She squeezed her with her tail, "Deep breaths, Adora, Halfmoon is safe; we have an army of people, all of whom are ready to help fight against anything like that," she tried to reason, but the girl just looked more shaken.

"But what if they're not ready," she said. "It happened before, that's how I got here." Adora didn't talk much about the day she left her old life behind, but clearly the fact she was even given a choice scared her.

"So, you wanted to, what? Join the temple guard?" she asked and the girl nodded. No chance there, the temple guards were very strict about who could and couldn't join and it definitely had a no children clause even for training. It was generally made up of veterans of other fields who had found faith but couldn't put down the sword. "Kelara wouldn't allow it until you're older." Adora grumbled her same *'stupid magic numbers'* under her breath. "But how about we go talk to the King-Consort? See if he'll train you."

Adora's eyes went wide—he *did* say a year ago that he'd teach her when she was older and she was older now. So, he had to stick to his promise. She bounced to her feet; Cyrus was the best fighter she'd ever seen, even better than Commander Cobalt. Even better than Askar. If he taught her then she would be able to protect everyone, like he did for her and Catra.

Kesi shouldered the bag she was carrying and held out a hand. Adora took it and the two of them left her small room for the city of Halfmoon and, by the end of today, Adora was sure she would be back on the path of the warrior.

Cyrus' Office

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Year After the Coup Attempt

Cyrus could feel the headache beginning to form. Of course on top of everything that had happened with the council, his sleepless nights spent with his new kitten, and the Horde upping their aggression, he now had a seven year old wandering around after him demanding he teach her how to fight and it's not that he didn't want to. The girl kept asking, and hadn't stopped for two years, but what kind of father would he be if he put the girl he was fairly sure his daughter was smitten with in mortal peril.

So, now, her and his eldest daughter were sitting in his office while he tried to finish a bunch of reports and Adora showed his daughter tricks with a knife. He had moved to sit next to them ready to snatch the knife out of the air if anything went wrong. He could afford the injury.

She flipped the knife between her fingers with the dexterity of one of the Salenian Water Dancers while trying to make eye contact with him. He had to admit it was impressive; her skills with a knife were exceptional and she was as good with a staff as many of the sixteen-year-old recruits, even if she lacked the muscle mass. *Dammit, no, do not talk yourself into letting her train.*

He spent a few minutes writing out the report. He could play the waiting game, wait for Catra to get bored of the knife tricks, or Adora to struggle with one and he could take over. But no, she kept doing them perfectly and Catra's eyes were focused on the spinning blade. With a final press of the pen to paper, he pushed the document away.

"Alright, Little Lion." As he said that, she flipped the knife from one hand to the other and sheathed it in a single motion. He had to admit doing that without getting any cuts was impressive, but that might explain some of the scarring on her palms. Not all of them but some of them. "You wanted to talk about continuing your training."

She nodded like an excited puppy. "Yes, King Tiger. I want to be able to fight. I want to train to fight. Like I should have been doing for the last two years!" He raised an eyebrow at that, his tail twitching slightly.

"Don't you feel safe in Halfmoon?" he asked as he moved his tail over to lay in her lap. If she was anxious about something, she could play with it to keep her calm. (He had noticed she had liked to have something in her hands to fiddle with; he would rather it be his tail than the knife.)

She gently stroked his tail, looking away from his face. "I get scared…" she said slowly. Kesi wrapped an arm over her shoulder. "I get scared that the Horde will come, and they'll take me back. Or they'll take Kesi," the older girl hugged her tighter and let out a soothing purr, "or Catra, or they'll hurt you or the Queen or the kitten." He could feel wet pinpricks on his tail. The girl's tears fell freely, something he had not seen her do, well, ever. His own

heart clenched; he had the same fears. Of not being enough. He hadn't been enough to protect his cousin from whatever mess he had ended up in that got him killed. To prevent all of the empty cots. To save Lyra's family. To stop Catra being taken again back to the witch in the Fright Zone. "And I know it's stupid," she continued, hiccuping through the tears, "but, if I can fight, maybe I can protect one of you." She turned and buried her face into Kesi's neck, sniffling something. The older girl looked apologetically at and mouthed an apology to the King-Consort. After a minute, Adora had steadied herself.

"You don't need protecting," she said to him, "because you can fight, but Catra can't, Kesi can't, the baby can't. I want to help protect them. If there are three of us, with Askar, then we can protect everyone, right?" Her eyes were red-rimmed and puffy with tears "So, please don't make me wait to be able to protect them!" she wailed.

Kesi held her tighter. "I am with you," he heard her whisper to the blonde girl. "If this is who you choose to be then, I am with you until the end." The girl continued to sob.

He exhaled. "Take a deep breath, Adora; breathing is important." She took several shaky breaths in. "I can see this is important to you." She nodded once while trying to intake a big breath. She hiccuped at that. Kesi gently rubbed her back. He waited for the hiccuping to cease. "So, I'll take you to Lyra." Adora looked confused at that. "And I'll ask her if I can train you. If she says yes, then I'll take you to the *tenemos* where me and Askar will figure out how best to train you, so you are ready." The girl looked beyond excited. "So that, when you turn eighteen, you can join any faction of the army without going through basic training." The girl was positively vibrating with glee. "But." She stopped. "If she says no, then I will not officially train you until you come of age." He hoped she noticed that left unofficial training as an option; sure ,it wouldn't be as good, but it was something and this girl needed to hold a weapon. It's like she was born to wield a sword. Adora's face fell; Lyra was very much against training children to

fight in a war. Adora thought that was stupid, but she was a child who wanted to fight in a war, so her opinion was discounted.

"Okay, but please, ask her properly. I want to train again," the girl begged. And how could he say no to that face? Especially after his daughter had climbed into her lap and started purring. Catra was batting at his tail so he removed it from Adora's lap and Catra curled further into the space that was left.

He sighed, and reached for his tablet. He sent a short message to Lyra, who was currently stuck in a meeting with the council regarding plans to expand housing into the lower districts further out from the Crescent Market and towards the eastern reach of the Dark Lake, and opening a school near there.

"*When you're free, come to my office. I have a sobbing child who needs to ask you a question, another purring in her lap, and a third looking increasingly uncomfortable being in a royal office who is* also *purring."*

He went back to his reports after giving the girls a game to play and setting Adora the task of learning *Aiilyara* sign language. Adora already knew Horde battle sign; apparently, it was drilled into crechlings while they were learning Etherian.

A few hours later, a disheveled looking Lyra turned up carrying the baby princess in one arm. She took a look at the room, and flopped down onto the couch, displacing Kesi who stood and curtsied when the Queen had entered. Kesi moved to sit on the floor with Adora and Catra.

He approached her, and scooped the child up into his arms, who babbled at him. With an "Up Dada", and he obliged his children. So, holding his youngest, he looked at his exhausted wife. "Rough Day?"

"I want to incinerate Haverisk," was all she said, eyes closed and hand draped over her head.

“How about tea instead?” He tapped the tablet on the desk a few times and sent a message to Percival to bring something for the Queen and juice for the little ones. “Kesi?”

She looked shocked at being addressed “Ummm…Tea for me as well?” she phrased her answer as a question. But he would accept that. He sent the message off to Perci and sat at his desk, bouncing his child on his knee. Adora was staring at him with the impatience that someone who had only lived less than a decade could muster; so little time that every minute felt like an hour.

“Beloved,” he started, “I know this is going to sound dangerous,” her ears perked up and she cracked an amber eye to look at him, “but Adora has come here to ask to begin her training again,” the Queen chuckled under her breath, “and I know you’ve been against the Idea of letting her train, but.”

“She has my permission,” the Queen said from her lying down position.

“She honestly wants to… I’m sorry.” Adora was already jumping for joy, Kesi and Catra both clinging to her as she leapt around the room.

“She has been asking to train for two years; her dedication hasn’t wavered.” She switched to *Aiilyara* and gestured for him to get close. “I want her trained as a Knight to protect the kittens. Like we plan with Kittrina,” she whispered so that only he could catch it. Kittrina, who had shined in the *tenemos* coming under his tutelage as a staff fighter rather than Askar for *kirith.* They were taking strides to turn the girl into a bodyguard for the youngest princess, who had taken an instant shine to her as Auntie Kit. The girl, in turn, was utterly devoted to protecting the kitten, and looking after her when both Lyra and Cyrus were too busy. To do that between Adora and Catra seemed like a great solution. “A royal guard gets her out of the temple and back next to C’yara.” He nodded, glad he and his wife shared that thought at least. It fit with her other plan to get Kesi onto Catra’s staff when she turned sixteen; the girl would be an adult by then, but she had

already thought about who would fit on Catra's staff for years and someone close to her age that she listened to would be for the best. Kesi fit the bill.

He turned back to the girls who were hugging in a way he was sure would cut off circulation to at least one of them. "Alright, Adora. Tomorrow morning, first moonrise, you come to the *tenemos* and we'll figure out how to train you." The girl was smiling like the Stars Above.

The tea and fruit juices arrived and he knew something had shifted, some fundamental aspect of the world had slid into place, while his daughter and her two friends sat on the floor, and his wife sipped tea. He was just not sure if it was a good or bad thing.

Askar's *Tenemos*

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After the Coup Attempt

The next day, Adora had arrived just before Cyrus, but not before Askar to the *tenemos.* She was wearing a cave culture outfit of black cloth that wrapped around her torso and over the back of her shoulders (it was probably the most practical outfit anyone in cave culture wore) as well as a pair of long legged pants that had slits on the outside, but were tucked military style into a pair of shin-high leather boots. He had no idea where the kid had acquired those, but he suspected Kesi had something to do with it.

Askar was already running her through basic drills when he arrived, tisane and three mugs in hand. His apology gift to the

ahran of the *tenemos* was to keep him caffeinated when early morning rolled around. The girl was good, better than any except Kittrina in that opening day of training on the day Ishara had been born.

Askar, to his credit—after he had complained about the plan for an hour-and-half to his face last night—was treating the girl like he would any other recruit and, for the first time, Adora really seemed to fall into something with absolute gusto that wasn't food or dragon based.

He had run her through exercises in general health, which she had passed with flying colours. He knew she would pass all of that; Lenio was careful with her and made sure she was as fit as could be considering all the question marks around her health. He settled into a seat, pulled out his tablet, and began to make notes on her form and skills. He would normally keep these as mental tallies but, to be honest, he was frazzled; yesterday had been a lot.

Over the next few hours, they ran through drills with her: fists (usually this would be with her claws but, as this little lion lacked claws, it came down to something Askar called "boxing"), knives (which he knew she was already great with), a quarterstaff (she was better than any recruit had a right to be; just what was the Horde teaching this kid?). She had no skill with the axe, or the bow and arrow favoured by scouts and certain units used to old forest fighting. But it was after a few hours and the girl was starting to get exhausted, that Askar took a practice sword, and handed it to her. She fell into a stance that was almost-but-not-quite what she had seen Askar do every day during training.

Askar's eyebrows shot up, and he ran her through a set of the training drills for *kirith.* It wasn't flawless but, for someone holding a sword for the first time, it was as damn close to perfection as a seven year old could come. He doubted he could do something similar at sixteen and he had been good back then.

Askar had run her through the drill twice more, adding more variance to it. He gently corrected her form, each time, and the adjustments stuck. She was breathing well. Not perfectly but as good as a student with a month or so of practice. (When asked, she said it was something called "Walking Stance" and that someone called Commander Cobalt had taught her.)

After the third drill in *kirith* and the thirtieth of the day overall, the girl looked dead on her feet. So, he walked over and plucked the sword out of her hands in the middle of a clumsy and tired swing. "That's enough for today," he said. And she mumbled something as he scooped her up into his arms. "Let's get you back to bed."

"'m not tired" yawned the little lion in his arms. She was still just a kitten in his eyes. Askar looked over at him and stared down at the girl.

"She's my newest apprentice now." he said. "You keep your strange, unnatural fighting style away from her; She's a Sword Saint in the making."

The girl half cheered, half yawned in his arms. He winked down at her; what Askar didn't know wouldn't hurt him. "Of course, Askar. You set the schedule and clear it with Kelara." That was one job he now didn't have to deal with. She had shown an aptitude for a weapon in each hand, which *kirith* would not teach but he knew such training would come in handy.

The old general grunted; an affirmative Cyrus thought. "I will want her here at least four times a week. Long training days." The girl's head lulled in his arms in what could have been a nod, and her strange not-purr rumbled through him.

"That's between you, her, and the priestess now since I'm not allowed to taint her training with my 'unnatural fighting style' so go speak to her." The girl was snoring in his arms.

He left the *tenemos* with the girl fast asleep, exhaustion from what it turned out was thirteen solid hours of training had seeped

into her bones. He made the journey back to her room, and nudged open the unlocked door.

Inside sat Kesi, reading a book. Her eyes went wide as he entered carrying her. “Your Majesty.” She curtsied. “Is she alright?” The girl looked panicked over Adora. She had a few bruises that you get from training that long.

“Nothing that a good night's sleep won’t fix,” he said, gently tucking her into bed. He pulled over a small, stuffed dragon that someone into cave culture had made for her last birthday; it was heavy like a paperweight. The girl instinctively wrapped herself around it.

“So, that’s it then?” Kesi asked. “She’s going to train to fight?” There was both hope and fear in her eyes. A strange mix of protectiveness over the smaller girl. Kesi was a child as well, but she always projected maturity. He put a hand on her back to guide her out of the room.

“One day, she’ll be a Knight of Halfmoon,” he said with paternal pride for his little lion who was snoring away on a softer pillow.

She dreamt of her training, of Askar, of Catra and Kesi watching her, safe behind her. She was their shield; no one could hurt them now that she was learning to fight. She was their *protection*.

And, in her deepest dream at the dead of the night, she dreamt of a forest of twisting trees.

And she dreamt of a sword wrapped in vines.

End Notes

I would like to thank Zelenal for making this readable, and for Aoife for coming up with the original idea of this AU, which has spiraled out of control. You can find out more on the Defiance Discord

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!